Session 16

2025-07-13

1 - A quiet day

~08:00, 7 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan rolls out under a clear sky and travels a full day on the road: open plains, sparse copses of trees, no travellers on the road and no trouble in sight.
2. The rest of the day passes without incident. Nightfall camp goes down at another of the road's stopping points; **Eguzkilore** volunteers for the last four hours of the watch on the strength of his elven trance, banking a little more goodwill with the caravan's guards, and the second night on the road ends as quietly as the first.
3. At breakfast the next morning each merchant serves his own guards from his own stores: **Lai**'s porridge is cheap and hot; **Edhelri** serves better porridge with fruit; **Noohar** tops his with a little honey for flavour.
4. The caravan is two days out of Baldur's Gate; the country is open plains, sparse copses of trees, and the low tumulus-shaped hills on the horizon that mark the outer edge of the Trollclaws — five days off at their pace.
5. Over porridge the caravan guards make small talk with the party: everyone shares the same wish for a quiet two months of road, because when something happens they have to work, and none of them like working when it means risking their necks.

2 - Amidamaru's boar

~11:00, 8 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Amidamaru keeps Munin overhead all morning, careful to stay within a hundred feet of the owl — beyond that tether the telepathic contact and the sight through his eyes both drop. He keeps the bird close.
2. Four hours out from camp, Munin catches a boar off the road, roughly five hundred feet away. Amidamaru relays it to Nuberroca low, not to the whole group, so the caravan does not tie the message to the bird.
3. Nuberroca announces to Edhelri that he is going to fetch food, gets waved off without protest, and sprints out with a crossbow. A twenty-minute chase brings him inside a hundred and fifty feet; he snaps off a long shot he does not expect to land, and instead sinks a bolt into the boar's haunch.
4. The boar turns rather than flees. Nuberroca is already laughing as it charges; he plants the spear butt into the ground and the boar drives itself onto the shaft. He lifts the carcass clear on the shaft over his head.
5. He smears himself in the boar's blood on the walk back — no river within a day and a half — and rejoins the caravan half an hour later, still dripping, shouting to anyone who will listen that lunch is on him.
6. Told the Chionthar is two days and a half behind and the Winding Water still five days off — and that no one recommends bathing in the second one — Nuberroca cleans the blood off with wet grass and bark instead. A man of the outdoors, the group agrees.

3 – The midday halt

~14:00, 8 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Two in the afternoon, the caravan pulls off the road to eat. It is forty in all — thirty-odd guards, the merchants, the family, the two travelling carts — and the fires collapse into a single circle around the boar.
2. **Beyd** volunteers to cook the roast, claiming a caravaneer's practice with spits. Nuberroca donates one of his four spears — puts it through the carcass end to end and hands it over, drawing a mild rebuke about gutting the boar first.
3. The spit is jury-rigged between two forked sticks. Beyd asks Nuberroca to turn it — the goliath has the strength, Beyd does not — and while Nuberroca turns, Beyd bastes the roast with a splash of his own beer.
4. While the boar cooks Amidamaru slips onto his own cart with Munin on his shoulder, casts *invisibility* on the owl, and sends him through the tarps of the three cultist wagons in turn. Every one holds the same nailed-shut crates and no one inside.
5. Meals divide by employer at the plates as they did before. Beyd works his fire, selling beer at a silver a jar; he gives Nuberroca two jars free on the boar and Nuberroca drinks both on the spot.
6. The travelling family comes to the fire. Nuberroca waves them in warmly. Mialee joins them to make conversation. A gnome — travelling separately from the family though he shares their cart — sits apart, working the guards for a dice game.
7. The cultists come to the fire last. Their guard — the same one who had turned Nuberroca off the cultist wagons at an earlier camp — draws his knife to cut a slice without a word. Nuberroca catches the wrist, lifts the man near clear of the ground, and tells him he needs to ask permission first.
8. The cultist folds — they are merchants bound for Waterdeep, their guards had assumed the roast was for sharing — and Nuberroca steps back with a warning: the soldiers had best be well fed for whatever lies ahead. They take a slice and go.
9. The gnome, **Radecere Perethun**, asks Mialee's group for a game. She sits down opposite him. Five dice each, highest scores; the gnome opens with four fives and a six, exceptional, and Mialee comes over the top with four sixes and a five.
10. He asks for double-or-nothing and loses again. He asks for one more, four silver in the pot; he throws three sixes, a five and a four, near-unbeatable, and Mialee still lands one point over him. Radecere pays out seven silver total, retreats to his cart, and eats his slice of boar alone.
11. Mialee remarks afterwards that she had planned to cheat and never needed to. Amidamaru — watching from the far side — assumed she had cheated the whole time regardless.

4 – The evening ride

~19:00, 8 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Four hours further, well into the evening, the caravan is closing on the small tumulus-like hills that mark the outer edge of troll country — still five days out. Beyd's horses stay poorly kept as before, freed to graze only when he remembers, mostly ignored while he sells beer.
2. Munin's cover slips along the ride: he is a night bird flying under a hard sun, and one of the caravan guards asks Amidamaru how he keeps the owl awake. Amidamaru admits it openly — the owl is his familiar, he hides him only when he is working.
3. What the guards do talk about, over and over, is the trolls: not every caravan on this road makes it out, and the fear runs the full length of the line.
4. Camp goes down for the night in one of the pre-established stopping points that dot the road — a cleared and reused spot with good sightlines. Eguzkilore offers a full four-hour shift on the strength of his elven trance; Nuberroca takes another.
5. The party debates whether to move on the cultists tonight. Amidamaru presses for information — they still know almost nothing. Nuberroca offers to grab one and beat it out of him. Mialee counters that a missing man means questions the next morning. Eguzkilore's proposal wins the room — wait for troll country, when a disappearance can be blamed on the road — and Nuberroca stands down, agreeing to turn in.
6. The night passes without incident.

5 – The men in the road

~08:00, 9 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Wake, breakfast — no boar left, back to the standard fare. Mialee slips a small illusion into Nuberroca's plate, a smiley worked into the porridge. Nuberroca spots the trick, grins the same grin back at her, and tells her she is a good one.
2. Beyd works his fire again and pitches beer as morning hydration under a hard sun. No takers today — the only regular wine-drinker in the party, Nyx, is not thirsty.
3. About three and a half hours down the road, closing on the day's usual break, Munin from overhead catches a knot of figures standing across the road ahead — perhaps four hundred feet off, in a small stand of trees.
4. Amidamaru signals the caravan to halt. The lead driver pulls up on a single guard's word, and murmurs run down the line asking why.
5. The tortle advances up the road with two guards behind him. Nuberroca peels off into the tree line to the west without any pretence at stealth — a nine-foot blue giant, in his own words, invisible only to the willing.
6. Eguzkilore falls in behind Amidamaru. Mialee stays with Edhelri on the wagon. Kaelthar, arriving late to the scene, joins Mialee at the rear.
7. At speaking distance the party makes out five men. The one in the middle wears richer clothes and carries himself as the leader; at his belt hangs a strange cylinder of metal with a wooden butt, the like of which none of them have ever seen.
8. The leader greets them and asks who speaks for the caravan. Amidamaru steps forward: no formal spokesperson, but they can help. The leader turns it around — the caravan will enter the fields of the dead in three or four days, and it will need protection.

6 – The negotiation

~11:30, 9 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Amidamaru points to the caravan guards behind him — this caravan has hired protection already. Ignoring that, the leader names the price: two hundred gold across the caravan, until the Trollclaws. Nuberroca, still sitting on a tree stump like a king on his throne, laughs at the word *trolls* — he has faced a dragon and been unimpressed.
2. Amidamaru sends a guard back to the merchants with a counter-offer at fifty gold, and reads the situation quietly to him — fifty-fifty these are bandits, closer to eighty-twenty. On the strength of Nuberroca's dragon boast, the leader drops his own price to a hundred and fifty.
3. Amidamaru sends Munin toward the sound of muffled laughter he keeps hearing in the trees on the far side of the meeting. The leader spots the owl instantly — *why is an owl flying by day?* — and his four crossbowmen come up with weapons on Munin.
4. Amidamaru makes Munin vanish in the instant before the first bolt looses; the bolt whistles through the empty air where the owl had been, and the four crossbowmen stand there gaping and reloading. The leader takes it for wizardry: *"¿qué te crees, que nunca hemos visto un mago?"*.
5. Eguzkilore's eyes on the trees find the shape of a bandit behind every trunk for thirty yards — six or seven of them crouched in the trees to the north and west, more figures than the five in the road. He readies a shot for the first hostile move.
6. Nuberroca stays on the stump, hears the crossbows around him cocking one after another, and calls it out loud and clear: the crossbows are aimed — let the fight begin. He sets himself ready to answer any strike on him with a killing fury.
7. Kaelthar takes hold of his sword-hilt but keeps it sheathed. The leader ups the price back to two hundred on the party's posture, and gives them a moment to accept the offer or turn around — hand never leaving the cylinder at his belt.
8. Amidamaru offers the last number the merchants would carry — fifty gold, one small stipend, take it or leave it. The leader calls fifty pieces an insult. Nuberroca stands, shouts back to have it their way, and steps behind the cover of a tree with Eguzkilore, roaring into a full fury as the fight opens.

7 - The ambush

1. The leader gives the word to his crew — at them. The first bolt from the tree line comes for Nuberroca, chips bark off the trunk, misses.
2. Nuberroca's readied crossbow answers before the shooter's next breath — bolt through the neck, the bandit falls out of the tree dead. Eguzkilore, who had readied his own shot on the same man, sees him drop and holds his arrow for the leader instead.
3. Eleven more bolts arc at Nuberroca from the treeline in the next volley. Four bite, but between his rage and the cover of the trunk barely a scratch bleeds through — a blue glow settles over him and the scratches close as they open.
4. One of Amidamaru's two escort guards takes a bolt at the first volley, foams blood at the mouth and falls dead in seconds — the caravan's first loss.
5. A second volley cracks against Amidamaru — twelve bolts, most turned in mid-flight by a curtain of blue light around the tortoise's shell. Two get through: one lodges at the base of his neck, another sinks in at the temple. He is left on his feet, bleeding badly from the throat and the skull, and drops flat behind his cover.
6. Two of the mercenary captains bring up the strange metal cylinders — a thunder-crack cuts through the trees, and Nuberroca catches one of the shots square: a piece of metal buried under his collarbone.
7. A blue glow settles over Nuberroca — the flesh closes around the metal ball where it stays lodged.
8. Mialee, still hidden with the wagons, casts a cloud of fog across the eastern half of the field — the archers on the far right are blinded to the caravan and vice versa, and Mialee slips into her own fog invisible to the shooters.
9. Amidamaru, prone under his cover, calls up a *chromatic orb* of acid from a diamond in his palm and hurls it at one of the mercenary captains. The orb splashes hard: the captain's clothes begin to melt off him, and he claws at himself and screams.
10. Nuberroca steps out of a wisp of cloud on the far side of the battlefield and puts himself behind the screen of bandits guarding the leader, driving a spear thrust through one who staggers but holds.
11. Kaelthar runs from the caravan into the fight and catches a bolt in one shoulder on the way in. He tries breathing fire through the fog toward the left-flank archers; the cone catches three of them but they shake off most of it, and the sheltering tree behind them catches fire.
12. Amidamaru, prone in his cover, casts a slumber spell across the tight cluster of bandits around the leader. Two go down where they stood — a bandit and the leader himself, the same man who had opened the negotiation.
13. Eguzkilore drops one of the exposed archers with an arrow — a clean shot; the bandit falls dead.
14. Nuberroca leaps at another of the mercenary captains through the fog's edge — a lance strike opens the man up, then the polearm's butt hammers into his neck and the captain crumples to the ground barely alive. Nuberroca shouts Amidamaru's name and legs it back to cover, dropping flat behind his tree; a blue glow settles over him and his wounds close.
15. Mialee moves through her own fog unseen — the bandits on the left cannot find her. She reaches one of them on their flank and cuts him down with a scimitar in the back.
16. Amidamaru calls another *chromatic orb* out of his diamond — this one fire — and it splashes on a bandit further up the tree line. The bandit ignites and collapses into a pile of ash; Kaelthar and the two bandits beside him are left staring at what remains.
17. The dragonborn, isolated on the fog's edge, is ringed by four bandits — heavy strikes bite through his guard and he holds only briefly before two more blows put him unconscious.
18. Eguzkilore fires at the enemies fighting Kaelthar despite the odds of hitting his friend, the shot lands clean and a bandit drops dead.
19. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca closes on the ring around the paladin, drops his spear for the halberd, and swings — a reckless cut that takes the first bandit at the ribs, drives clean through his spine and buries in the second. The first falls in two pieces; the second sinks to his knees and dies. Nuberroca calls back to the party to regroup — the ambushers are running — and what is left of them breaks and scatters into the woods.

8 - After the ambush

~12:00, 9 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Kaelthar is bleeding out on his back. Eguzkilore pulls a healing potion from his own pack, tips it into Kaelthar's mouth, and Kaelthar opens his eyes barely alive — Eguzkilore over him, Amidamaru behind, Nuberroca off to his left; and behind them the caravan guards standing over two of their own dead on the ground beside a fallen bandit.
2. Two caravan guards have fallen in the fight; the party accounted for most of the ambushers themselves, with the guards' bolts contributing at range once they closed on the fight.
3. Nuberroca goes to the captain he had knocked out with his polearm butt — the man is dying on the ground — and stabilises him with his own healer's kit, then binds his wrists with cord out of his pack.
4. Amidamaru ties off the two men still asleep from the same spell — one captain, one common bandit — and the party ends the fight with three prisoners: the leader, a captain and one bandit.